

9.5 Scandisk And Chkdsk

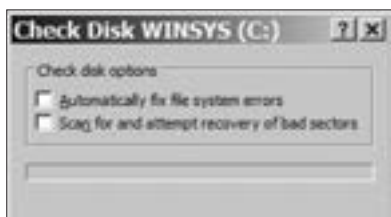
Maintenance of your hard disk involves periodically checking it for errors. Errors include file system errors and bad sectors. A file system error leads to strange system behaviour. It can be caused by, for example, a power outage when a file is being written. A bad sector occurs when a “sector” (the basic unit of data storage on a hard disk) becomes unfit for writing to or reading from, and is marked as such.

9.5.1 Scandisk

Windows 98 shipped with a program called Scandisk; this is hidden in Windows XP. You get to it by opening Windows Explorer, right-clicking on a drive, clicking Properties, and selecting the Tools tab.



The Tools tab for a hard disk



Clicking ‘Check Now’ brings this box up

Once here, under ‘Error Checking’, clicking ‘Check Now’ brings up a little window with four options—‘Automatically fix file system errors’, ‘Scan and attempt recovery of bad sectors’, and, of course, ‘Start’ and ‘Cancel’.

File system errors are more common than bad sectors, and you will usually want Windows to automatically fix them—so you’ll usually want to check the first box. You’ll want to check the second box only if you want to do a thorough, physical scan of the hard disk, which is not often, but nevertheless important once in